SpeechGeek

Season Four: Spring 2007

ISSN 1545-9209 Price $25 US
http://www.speechgeek.com

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ISSN 1545-9209

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SpeechGeek is published three to four times per year: August, October, December, and (sometimes) April by Corey Alderdice, 959 Morgantown Rd., Apt. 3, Bowling Green, Kentucky 42101

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In just a matter of a few weeks we'll move into a new year. For those of us in the world of education, it traditionally marks the halfway point of the school year. Though everyone else has their minds on starting from scratch, we're in the thick of things. For many forensic coaches, now is the time of year when you address what's working with your team and what exactly isn't.

A little introspection never hurt anyone.

Challenge your students to pick up the pace as we move down the stretch toward state tournaments, qualifiers, and (they'll be here before you know it) Nationals. The first semester doesn't really matter any more. Come January, you'll be rested and ready to go.

Okay, maybe the sense of renewal the new year brings isn't really all that different between forensicators and the real world.

That could very well be a first.

Best of luck as your season continues! It is my that 2007 is filled with fun adventure for both you and your program.

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

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Thrift

by Daschle Stephens

Humiliation has always played an integral part in self-discovery, and I suppose my life is no different. In my high school Intro to Drama class – we had to go around the room and introduce ourselves by telling everyone what animal we were most like. The other guys were panthers. They were grizzlies, lions, eagles, and boa constrictors – they were beasts of power, strength, and virility. Me? I was a squirrel. So while every other turbo-testosterone charged teen male was on the prowl – I was left open to a barrage of hi-larious innuendos about my "nuts". It never got old.

Now in my own defense, the squirrel thing isn't as asinine as it may sound. Growing up, money was tight around my house. We were by no means starving, but we had a healthy appreciation for what we had. Much like squirrels, my younger brother, Kevin, and I were always on the lookout to gather resources for home. If we were good during the week, my mom would take the two of us out to McDonald's for a family dinner on Friday. After finishing our Happy Meals, my brother and I would make sure to grab extra salt, pepper, and packets of "fancy ketchup" to take home for future dinners. At age 8 this ritual is charming and endearing. At age 28 you're called cheap by merciless friends and coworkers – to which I always respond, "Back off – my meatloaf is now delicious *and* fancy."

Sundays were always spent diving through the paper for the coupons and sale sections. Eventually my brother and I would create games to make the task of bargain hunting for mom a little more enjoyable. Sometimes we would compare products at different stores to see who had the best deals, and to make the stakes more interesting: the one with the lower price gave the other an Indian Sunburn or during the holidays – a delightful Texas Tittie Twister. Scissors askew - we flew like starving junkyard dogs through the sections. Kevin had an eye for office supplies and clothing sales but I always delivered a weekly whooping when it came to frozen foods and produce. Working two jobs to make ends meet, my mom appreciated the help though she never really saw the need to spend money on the frivolous things that kids find to be the most important. Case in point – neither Kevin nor I ever had a real lunchbox. And by real, I do mean the plastic box with a cartoon or action hero on the front. Mom figured that the plastic bags that we brought home our groceries in worked just fine. This never really bothered me, but it always seemed to irritate the other kids at school who felt the need to show off: A). The lunchboxes that their parents bought them and B). The unforgiving physics the thin bag had on my chips when met with someone's balled up fist before walking to the bathroom.

It was at this point that I usually emptied the contents of a packet of "fancy ketchup" into one of their open cans of Dr. Pepper. The projectile vomiting that followed would ensure the safety of my chips in the future. But this didn't stop my mom from trying to stencil Optimus Prime on my grocery bag the next day out of guilt.

*

If being thrifty made me the weird kid – it has also made me an awkward adult. As I move grudgingly through the end of my 20's, I still have the charm of Beaver Cleaver in the throes of puberty. My hair cowlicks in angles not found in advanced geometry classes, my clothes are so far from being name brand that the tags are blank, I can never find anything witty to say and I laugh like Pee-Wee Herman. Ladies…control yourselves. One good thing to come of my money conscious upbringing was the ability to crunch numbers freakishly well resulting in a passion for mathematics and yet another way to drive away the opposite sex. These days I work as a computer programmer at a faceless corporation. Sure, there are the same predator archetypes in the work place as there were in high school – but for every squirrel there are a dozen lions and panthers ready to bust my bushy behind into submission. There's a reason why you don't see many squirrels

Topaz

by Paul Davis

(*The narrator is calling for a dog. He has a limp in one of his legs*) Topaz! Here boy! (*Tries to whistle. He notices the audience*) I've never been able to whistle. Never learned I guess. Whatever. (*Back to looking for the dog*) Topaz! Come here, boy. (*To audience again*) Did you lose a dog too? I know what you're thinking: "Who names their dog Topaz?" My retarded sister, that's who. Hey, she's my sister, its okay for me to call her retarded. Well, she's not totally retarded; she's just in a wheelchair. Bum legs you know? She's the one who wanted Topaz, but who do you think has to walk him? Not her, I can guarantee you that. She gets out of all the chores just for being crippled. Sometimes I feel bad and all for her, but man, I hate chores. Especially walking this stupidly named dog. How do you think I feel having to call out his retarded name in public? It's embarrassing. TOPAZ! Man, I'd rather call him butt...licker. Even that's more dignified than Topaz. You know what's even more embarrassing? I lost him. He somehow snuck off his leash. We're walking, I stop to piss on a tree, turn around and he's gone. I have no idea how he did it. The leash is tied to my wrist. He must me magic, that is the only conclusion I can come up with. You know it's a bad day when you're afraid to go home for fear of getting your ass kicked by your crippled sister. Crippled sister. That would be a good name for a band. I have personally watched Topaz take a dump and then eat it. I have been witness to him eating his own fecal matter and he outwitted me. Outsmarted by Topaz. This is indeed a sad day in my life.

I do suppose that Topaz is a more original name than my last dog, Dog. Dog was his name. That one was my fault. I was under the impression that it would be clever or funny to name him that, but apparently I was way off. Every time someone would hear me call him, they'd say, "You named him dog? But he is a dog." Really? My dog's a dog? Thank you very much. I can't wait till I have a child. I'm really gonna throw dumb people through a loop when I name him human. Person has a nice ring to it. Anyways, at least I liked Dog. He was a good dog. Always by my side. Not like my wheelie-poppin' sisters. But you'll never guess how Dog died. Seriously, you'll never guess. Ever. Try. Go ahead, how do you think he died? Alright, I'll tell you, but you're not gonna believe me. This is the truth. Dog was eaten...by a freaking SHARK! No joke. My dog was eaten by a shark. You can imagine what kind of effect that could have on a child. Especially since I was in the water, not three feet away when it happened. We were swimming in the ocean and...did I even have to say that? It's not like a shark got him in the bathtub. Anyways, I'm floating on my stupid boogie board about twenty yards from the shore where my parents are keeping a protective eye on me. As if they could do anything if let's say, I don't know, a shark attacked. Maybe they could get there in time to salvage my hair. When the shark was done flossing with it. Anyways, I'm boogie boarding or whatever, looking at my cute dog, Dog, doggy paddlin' away when all or a sudden...out of the blue...without warning...before I knew what happened, WHAM! Shark attack. Instant chum. Dog was eaten like that. So my parents, with their watchful eye on me see my dog explode, see the water around me filling with blood and do you know what they did? Here's their reaction. (*Doing an impression of a stupid person pointing*) "Did you see that?" They pointed like it was something shiny or a man with two wieners, not their firstborn child about to be devoured by a giant fish. And they didn't even set one toe in the water. Didn't even meet me halfway. I asked them about it later and they said they were too shocked to move. You think that's shocking? Try being right next to it. You think I was too shocked to move? Here's what I did: "AAAHHHHH!!! My dog just got eaten by a freaking shark! Ahhhhh!! Holy crap! Save me! What the Hell?! Aaahhhh!" Meanwhile, I'm moving my legs faster than an Ethiopian chasing a running sandwich—what? I can say that...my sister is Ethiopian. Anyways, you know what happened? Apparently when a shark senses a lot of splashing around, they

think that it could be some wounded food or something. So, CHOMP, there goes my leg. Don't worry, it wasn't the whole thing. There was still tendons and bits of flesh hanging off. But at least I got this awesome upgrade. (*He pats his fake leg*) Now I think pirate jokes are even funnier, you know, since I can relate. Needless to say, kicking away from the shark wasn't working so well anymore. I was going in circles. Luckily, some people who cared about me, oh, not my parents mind you, total strangers, ran into the water and pulled me out. The doctors said I was lucky not to die of blood loss. Screw that, I was lucky not to be all the way eaten by a shark! I was lucky that Dog was always by my side. I always imagined that Dog saw the shark coming and doggy paddled his way into its path to save me. And I know it probably didn't happen like that, but I carried this around with me for the longest time. I was so bitter and angry at my parents and…sharks. At anyone but strangers. Strangers were the one's who saved me, strangers are the one's that always listen to your stories and it's always new to them. My parents don't like to talk about what happened. Anyways, I carried this with me until one day I heard an interesting bit of information. A shark's heart keeps beating for ten minutes after it dies. As interesting as this fact was, more interesting to me was to think of a shark with a heart. I don't mean like, sharks are heartless or anything like that. It's just that I never really though of the shark as having the same things inside that I do. That kind of put everything into perspective. The shark was just part of Mother Nature, doing what it does. Just like me or Dog or my parents or those strangers that ran into the ocean to pull me out. It wasn't anybodies fault. But I'm done with the ocean. That's the only way to be sure to be done with sharks. I though I was done with dogs too, but my sister wanted Topaz. Oh, by the way, her leg problems aren't from a shark or anything. She had polio at a young age; doctors didn't get to it till it was too late or something. Just in case you thought there was some kind of weird connection. Anyways. (*Back to looking for his dog*) Topaz! Here boy (*He whistles and immediately looks at the audience, stunned at his accomplishment*). Did you hear that? I did it. (*He notices the dog run up to him. He bends down to pat it and put its leash back on*) Hey, Topaz. Where you been boy? I bet you came cause I whistled. Never thought I'd be so happy to see you. Alright, put this back on you little turd. And no disappearing out of it this time. Come on Topaz, let's go home. (*Back to audience*) Hey, thanks for listening. Hope you find your dog. Take it easy.